the party and ministers in the government. They would each present their issues and concerns in a couple of minutes while handing over relevant papers. Senior Yatra coordinators and party leaders Jairam Ramesh, Digvijaya Singh and K. Raju sat in on these deliberations. At the conclusion of this, Rahul Gandhi was to be presented with five issues and demands that the Rajasthan civil society felt that, if implemented, would make a big difference to the lives of the people of the state and elsewhere.

These were: 1) The passage, as promised in the state party manifesto, of a Right to Health law in the state. This would be a first in the country, and along with the enhanced Chiranjeevi Swasthya Bima Yojana (the state hospitalization insurance scheme), would provide comprehensive and equal health coverage for all. 2) An enhanced rural and urban employment guarantee backed by law. 3) Proper implementation of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes special component plan legislation passed a year ago. 4) Libraries and Constitution kendras in every panchayat. 5) The social accountability law that the state Congress party and government had promised on numerous occasions, but clearly bowing to vested interests from the bureaucracy, were prevaricating about tabling, passing and implementing.

In his response, Rahul Gandhi strongly supported all five demands, and with the chief minister of the state sitting before him, said that he could see no reason why all five could not be done—and in an effective manner. Eventually in the Rajasthan budget announcements three months later, all five were converted into budget assurances. Barring the social accountability law, all were implemented as law or policy.

Overall Reflections on the Yatra

The padyatra has come back as a political tool in Indian politics. The BJY concluded in Srinagar and a year later another major yatra from east to west is taking place—this time called the Bharat Nyay Yatra (BNY). This yatra provides an opportunity to build on the strengths of the BJY. And yet, there